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Feminism and the Study of Literature¹

by Florence Howe

In 1969, for the first time, I gave a public lecture away from my own campus. The invitation came from a small midwestern university's English department: I was asked to talk about fiction, perhaps Doris Lessing about whom I had written, but if possible with a somewhat broader perspective. I chose to think about a question that had been on my mind for several years, since 1964, in fact, when, after returning from a freedom school in Jackson, Mississippi, I began to consider the relationship between the literature I was teaching and the lives of my students—all of whom were women. So I chose for my question, topic, and title—"Should Women Read Fiction?" My answer in 1969 was very embarrassing not only for the English department which had invited me—and all their students—but for my own teacherly life. My answer was no, women should not read fiction, unless they were either resolute about their own vocations or they were content to follow the path prescribed for most fictional heroines: marriage or death, these were the choices. I regretted my conclusion as feelingly as I could before an English department faculty and its students, but I could offer only the solace of Doris Lessing, of whom most people in the room knew little.

My analysis in 1969 was, it seems to me now, notable for its clarity of thought and argument, since it was based on remarkable ignorance. It was also based on a belief—which I do still hold—that literature affects the lives of those who read it. Perhaps I had become an English major and then an English teacher because I had been infected with a belief shared by critics as diverse as Matthew Arnold, Margaret Fuller, and Mao Tse Tung in the "power" of literature. I can't reconstruct that right now, but I was at least dimly aware through my whole life that literature was my invisible but open window out of the Jewish ghetto in which I was born and raised. High on my list of favorites were books like *Microbe Hunters*, a series of what were to me thrilling stories about the lives of male scientists. Literature was my door into other people's lives, values, beliefs, traditions. At the same time, it did not tell me that, as a woman, I had a scientific or political future. Indeed, and I have told this story before, the female character I felt closest to when I was in graduate school at Wisconsin was Dorothea Causabon, who, in my view, had not made the mistake of marrying, but only of choosing the wrong man to marry. Even then, I assumed that my ultimate purpose was marriage and child-bearing.

My 1969 analysis linked the idea of Elizabethan conduct books with the theory expressed in Ian Watt's *Rise of the Novel* that fiction became a significant literary form when significant numbers of middle-class women became both readers and writers. Watt makes the useful connection between the "domestic" subject mat-

ter of most fiction and the "domestic" lives of most middle-class women. My method in writing that paper was simplicity itself: I reviewed or reread all the "major" British fiction of the eighteenth, nineteenth, and twentieth centuries that I had been exposed to as a student in college and graduate school. I had also read a few "major" European and American novels (written by men) and included them in the "sample." In each case, I asked, "What happens to the women in the novel?" "How does the novel leave them at its conclusion?" And the answer was: either dead or married—or both.

But I have said also that this analysis was based on remarkable ignorance. In the main, this ignorance reflects the narrowness of the literary canon as I had studied it and as I was then teaching it. It is still, needless to say, the literary curriculum that prevails. But there were at least three other important aspects of that ignorance: first, ignorance of the hundreds of women writers who wrote, were published and read, at least in their own lifetimes, and even by other women writers of subsequent generations, but who never made it into the literary curriculum. Second, and as critical: ignorance of feminist polemical literature—from the eighteenth century forward, and on both sides of the Atlantic. Third, and most massive of all: the ignorance of the lives of women, educated or not, writers, lovers, revolutionaries, mothers, workers, sisters, witches, saints, slaves. In short, the ignorance was massive, for it reflected the fact that the education of all people—male and female—ignored half the human population, at least from conscious thought and critical study.

Only seven years have passed since 1969, but in response to a feminist movement now in its second decade, most disciplines are in some intellectual ferment. For two reasons, literature has been one of the leaders of that ferment.² Understood in its broadest possible meaning—as the written account of people's lives—literature is a primary source for studying lives of women; in addition, an extraordinary number of women were writers both in the professional sense and as diary or record keepers.³

In this essay I am more interested in the practice of literary criticism in the classroom than I am in reviewing the printed essay or book. Partly, it is that I have spent 25 years as a practicing classroom critic, teaching students the art of reading, of learning from literature. Partly, it is that feminist literary criticism, even in 1976, has few printed guides to its practice. There are a dozen or more suggestive essays and one fine new book—Ellen Moers' *Literary Women*—all of which will be helpful to the future systematizer. There are also the essential precursors, from whom all feminist critics have learned: deBeauvoir, Woolf, and Kate Millet. And, finally, there

is, in the second issue of *Signs*, a rich review by Elaine Showalter of feminist literary criticism published during the past several years. But there is no single book or essay of systematic theory. For the foreseeable future, I expect that it is in the classroom, rather than on the pages of professional journals, that the criticism we call "feminist" will perform its useful educational function.

Hence, I shall combine the pedagogical and the critical and, thus, ask of the new feminist literary criticism certain difficult questions. First, how does it, will it, affect the lives of students who read literature in schools and colleges? Second, what does its challenge to the traditional classroom signify for the future teaching of literature? Third, can feminist criticism gain power sufficient to alter significantly the literary canon? Fourth, how will feminist criticism and scholarship change our understanding of literary history? My method, like my questions, is not simple. I begin first by attempting to outline what I perceive as feminist criticism's central assertion: that the critic, the writer, and their audience—all are rooted in their biographies and historical circumstances. Art is neither anonymous nor universal; it springs from the particularities of gender as well as class, race, age, and cultural experience. Similarly, critical methods and concerns shift with time and circumstances, and of course these would be more diverse still were we open to hearing from a more diverse population of critics. Then I turn to the feminist practice of analyzing "images of women in literature," and finally, I consider women writers, and questions about the canon, literary value, and literary history.

The Central Assertion

What is even harder for students to understand than the common mortality of the writer is the more common mortality of the critic. Few students learn, even in colleges, about the shifting of critical views from age to age, much less about the relationship between those views and the lives of the people who espoused them or the societies in which these people lived. Students I have taught through the past two decades tend to believe that criticism is something handed down from above by "those who know," the ultimate judges sitting in state on every book. A student's tendency to assume that critics are those best able to apply transcendent, universally agreed upon standards to art reflects our own assumptions, as well as the rather narrow range of critical writers whom we have studied. We—I speak of the teachers of my generation now—also resist the idea that a critic's class, race, age, and gender have very much to do with the "literary" judgements he or she makes.

Naturally, students come to view their own roots and experiences as interfering with the development of true literary standards. I remember a freshman paper in defense of Mr. Morel in *Sons and Lovers*. He reminded her of her own father, she wrote, who drank and who was, therefore, according to her mother, "unreliable," and she described also the way in which her mother had managed to pit her children against her husband. The

student wove her own experiences into a convincing reading of Lawrence's opening chapters, presenting in detail those complexities Lawrence clearly savored about the battle between his parents. Yet, she concluded her paper with a strong paragraph of denial. "Probably I am all wrong," she wrote, "because my experience is too much like the experience in the novel." "Probably I am all wrong." For this student and for many others, "the shock of recognition" belongs only to the *real* critics.

I deliberately chose a pre-feminist or non-feminist example out of my classroom experience, for I first want to make the point that one's experience must be seen as *enabling*, not crippling or disqualifying. It is not that without an experience immediately relevant to the events in a book you need necessarily be lost: witness the generations of women who voluntarily forswore their experiences and entered the literary classroom as though they were anthropologists studying a foreign, male world. Many of us in 1976 understand the value of a particular experience in relation to *writers* of Black literature or of Jewish and other ethnic literatures. We have always understood it in relation to writers of national literatures. Applied to the critic, the idea is less acceptable. Applied to women and to men as writers or critics, it is still a very explosive idea.

When I first said in public that James Joyce and D. H. Lawrence were *male* writers whose views of women were limited by that perspective, I was attacked by outraged women and men, insisting that great literature was "universal." Even as late as 1972, when at the Midwest Modern Language Association meetings, I read from a preface to a new feminist anthology of poems, *No More Masks!*, describing W. B. Yeats' "Leda and the Swan" as a man's view of the woman and god, and comparing it with Mona Van Duyn's views of the same episode, I was villified for daring to besmirch the "greatness" of Yeats as poet by calling attention to his maleness.

Similarly, Ellen Moers' new book, *Literary Women: The Great Writers*, has been attacked both by male and female reviewers who cannot fathom the assumptions that have produced her book. Let me quote two sentences from Moers' preface that may or may not speak to you clearly:

Once I thought that segregating major writers from the general course of literary history simply because of their sex was insulting, but several things have changed my mind: (xiii)

If ever there was a time which teaches that one must know the history of women to understand the history of literature, it is now. (xiii)

Ellen Moers does not begin her book by describing, as Kate Millett did six years ago, the patriarchal society we live in. For better or worse (and worse, if the popular critics' response is considered), she assumes that in 1976, it is not necessary, that the consciousness of readers will have kept pace with her own. Instead, she opens the

book with three brilliantly rendered portraits of women writers: the domestic Mrs. Stowe, one year before beginning *Uncle Tom's Cabin*, writing to her sister-in-law about her troubles with a plumber, and describing also the dozen interruptions—children, neighbors, servants, domestic chores—in the course of writing her letter; the imprisoned Miss Barrett who is, however, so totally free of domesticity that she may learn foreign languages and read and write without interruption; and the indefatigable George Sand, freed by her male clothing to be, at once, mother, mistress, and prolific writer. But all the while, Ellen Moers is making one fact plain: the lives of women are utterly distinct from the lives of men.

It is hardly a novel discovery—that men's and women's lives are distinct each from each. The biblical chauvinist would insist that god meant it to be that way. And feminists, both female and male, have for centuries now challenged the logic, justice, and legitimacy of such distinctions when they limit the lives of women. As feminists have looked back into history and around them at the lives of women in their own time, they have noted first and perhaps in greatest detail thus far the victimization of women of all classes. But that view has been generally tempered—at least when the feminist was female—by the fact of her enabling vision, of her own survival in patriarchal floods. It is possible, today, to construct the history of women survivors—not only the singular figures of Wollstonecraft and Fuller, of Stowe, Barrett Browning, and Sand, but, as I shall suggest when I turn to literary history, of others whose names we do not yet recognize. That notion—that women have been not only victims but survivors with special talents resulting from their experiences—emerges in contemporary feminism in a song like Helen Reddy's "I am victorious. I am Woman." Or in a delighted acceptance by young poets of the charge of "witchery":

*I want my black dress.
I want my hair
curling wild around me.
I want my broomstick
from the closet where I hid it.
Tonight I meet my sisters
in the graveyard.
Around midnight
if you stop at a red light
in the wet city traffic,
watch for us against the moon.
We are screaming,
we are flying,
laughing, and won't stop.*

—Jean Tepperman (1969)

All feminist criticism—indeed, all the ferment in every intellectual discipline—is based on conclusions about the

distinctions between the lives of men and women. The feminist critic (who is usually but not necessarily female) begins with acute consciousness of her own life, of what it has allowed her to see well and of what it has denied her. Such consciousness has not sent her and other feminists into isolation. Rather, it has led to a growing body of research into the lives of women and men, into written documents—autobiographies, letters, poems, novels, as well as children's books; and into other cultural artifacts—pots and quilts, as well as paintings and the TV screen. In addition, feminist consciousness both derives from and leads back to a social movement that is principally a teaching movement, gathering into its wave the transformed consciousness of millions, not only here but around the world. In the classroom, therefore, the feminist critic is not a quirky individualist, "doing her thing," or grinding a dull axe. Rather, she or he speaks from the force of scholarship, history, and a growing social movement.

The feminist teacher speaks to students who have also been touched by the contemporary women's movement. Not only are women students more confident in the classroom; they may have also grown conscious of and articulate about the reality of their lives. Such consciousness often helps them to read literature with an insight that male students must be taught.

After an enjoyable classroom performance of key sections of Albee's *The American Dream*—a play members of the class had chosen to read—I asked the students who played the roles what feelings they had had as the characters, not only during this performance, but through several prior rehearsals. Both males reported that they had had "no feelings," that the characters they played were "alienated" from society; indeed, that was what the play itself was really about, they offered. When queried, they were vague about the sources of that alienation. The three females reported "some feelings," especially Mommy's for Grandma, and Grandma's for "The American Dream." The play, from their point of view, was not about alienation, but represented Albee's attack on females for controlling male sexuality and robbing them of manhood—and hence of feelings. The males in the class listened attentively, but they were essentially bewildered by the interpretation. They had not seen the portraits of the women in the play as unflattering or unusually critical, much less unjust or incorrect; possibly, they shared Albee's view of women. I say possibly, since it is, compared with Mailer's, for example, a relatively mild chauvinism. When we turned next to Mailer's *An American Dream*, the men in the class were the first to attack the viciousness of that book, or, as they put it also, its "lack of reality."

Through the medium of literary discussion, consciousness generates consciousness. We know that as

teachers. These days, in many classrooms, women's actual social experience becomes the driving force behind a review of literary perceptions and values.

"Images of Women in Literature"

Both the study of the images of women in literature and the study of women writers are part of much broader intellectual movements, and I think it is important to see them in that light, for they make connections between literature, other disciplines and our changing society. The study of the images of women in literature began as part of an examination of the cultural perpetuation of stereotypes about males and females, even in the face of very different reality. At a time when women were one-third of the work force, for example, why was it that one could find few or no portraits of salaried working women in literature of any sort, at any classroom level? Had no literature of that sort been written? Such studies began by focussing on literature because, unlike history, women were not absent from its pages. If women were present in stories, poems, children's books, feminists asked, what did they look like? What "images" of women were projected? What "messages" did those images convey?

We are all familiar by now with at least some study of children's literature. Scholarship in print and in film has compiled detailed views of girls training to be mothers. Domestic duties done, they patiently wait behind windows for something to happen, or they virtuously clean up a brothers' indoor messes, while brother scampers about the outside world, learning to be Dad's helper and an energetic, inventive, competitive working person. None of the responsibility—the travail or joy—associated with motherhood, moreover, appears in the literature offered to elementary or secondary students, nor is there a sign of the possibility of combining marriage, motherhood, and salaried work—as half the mothers in the U.S. do. Two visual images are particularly memorable in children's books: the apron, worn by females of all ages, whether human, rabbit, or great ape; the armless little girl, whose hands are joined behind her back.

I have been present when the accumulation of such images, presented in the form of slides, has women weep publicly for their motherly irresponsibility: they had bought all of those books for their daughters. If this seems rather extreme, if it makes you smile, consider what a young woman once said to justify her request that I teach a course on D. H. Lawrence: "I read fiction," she said, "to find out what to do with my life. Lawrence, I think, is one of the main people who will tell me."

In its essence, a study of the images of women in literature involves a methodology for examining the patterns of sex prejudice, either in the work of a particular writer, or a genre that involves several or many writers, or, in its most sociological manifestation, through thousands of children's textbooks or readers. The method extends also into an analysis of popular

magazines, films, television, etc. Sociological and literary techniques for investigating female characterization have been used not only by scholars but also by feminist parents challenging the bias of their children's schoolbooks, and by feminist teachers challenging the consciousness of students in the classroom. The approach is responsible for such publications as *Dick and Jane as Victims*, for Millett's *Sexual Politics*, for Carolyn Heilbrun's *Towards a Recognition of Androgyny*, as well as for a spate of critical essays, doctoral dissertations, and published books on women in the works of male writers. Feminists in philosophy, in religion, in art history, and so forth, are also engaged in similar work.

Hundreds of women's studies courses in English and foreign language departments, in high schools as well as colleges, are currently being given under the rubric of "Images of Women in Literature." Their presence, like other courses in women writers, indicates how immediately the classroom may be affected by social movements and scholarly energies. *Images of Women in Literature*, a text prepared by Mary Anne Ferguson during 1972 and published first in 1973, with such courses in mind, groups short fiction and poems into the following "images" of women: the "submissive wife," the "mother—angel or 'mom'," "the dominating wife—the bitch," "the seductress—goddess," "man's prey: the sex object," and "the old maid." Thus, Ferguson concludes that women in literature are portrayed chiefly in terms of their sexuality, not in terms of their capacities for work, thought, or social action. Ferguson's final section, "the liberated woman: what price freedom?" concludes with a question that underscores the relationship between literature and life, and renders—through the fiction of several women writers—the tensions, conflicts, and frustrations in the lives of women who have working lives—or who wish they had.

The authors in Ferguson's anthology are divided evenly—half male, half female. They contain the traditional Chekhov, Sherwood Anderson, and Mailer—and the nontraditional Ernest J. Gaines and Jean Toomer, Mary Wilkins Freeman, Susan Glaspell, and Mary Elizabeth Vroman. Similarly, though courses in "Images" began by reviewing the traditional canon—from Sophocles, Chaucer and Shakespeare, in some cases, through Hawthorne and James, to Hemingway and other moderns, mostly male—the fare needed leavening.

Images in the traditional canon, enriched even by extensive use of the few well-known women writers, still left unfulfilled at least two needs: for greater variety, especially in terms of race, class, and ethnicity; and for more positive images generally. The images, for example, of white working-class and black women who are feisty mothers as well as wage-earners sustaining their families break all kinds of stereotypes, even shallow feminist ones. When students first read Tillie Olsen's "I Stand Here Ironing," they blame the mother in the story for having spoiled her daughter's young life because, in order to support them both, the mother makes less than ideal arrangements for her young baby's care. Women

and men in my classes, many of them parents and not well-to-do, have at first judged this woman harshly and have found the portrait of a devoted, working-class mother a negative one. When they turn next to "Tell Me A Riddle," the story of a dying woman who has devoted the whole of her life to mothering, and who in great agony queries that choice and the meaning of life, the same students have judged her wanting: why, one woman asked, did she waste her whole life, especially since she was so talented as a young girl?

In a discussion recently of Alice Walker's stories of black women, *In Love and Trouble*, students named as favorite "Everyday Use," because as one man said, it was the only story that was "hopeful," the only one in which a woman said "no to her would-be colonizer." The woman who tells the story describes herself:

In real life I am a large, big-boned woman with rough, man-working hands. In the winter I wear flannel nightgowns to bed and overalls during the day. I can kill and clean a hog as mercilessly as a man. My fat keeps me hot in zero weather. I can work outside all day, breaking ice to get water for washing; I can eat pork liver cooked over the open fire minutes after it comes steaming from the hog. One winter I knocked a bull calf straight in the brain between the eyes with a sledge hammer and had the meat hung up to chill before nightfall. (48)

The woman is also the mother of two daughters, one still at home, lamed in childhood by a devastating fire, the other, with special beauty and "a style of her own," who returns in the course of the story, her name changed from "Dee" to "Wangero Leewanika Kemanjo." The story turns on quilts—found in a chest and promised by the mother to the lame daughter who is about to be married. They were made by two generations of *women* in the family, including the mother of the "man-working hands," who has to decide whether to allow her visiting daughter to take the quilts for her urban walls. The mother almost does decide to give in, but the acquiescence of her lame daughter, who says, "I can 'member Grandma Dee without the quilts," and who mutely accepts her less than equal share of life, makes her change her mind. The mother snatches the quilt from Dee who departs shortly thereafter, following a final barb to her sister and mother about their misunderstanding their "heritage." The story portrays not only conflicting images of black women, but conflicting views of their relationship to each other and to cultural artifacts, "heritage," even art.

The classroom discussion of such stories—setting aside for a moment the subject of mothering—would not have seemed strange to Arnold or Emerson, for whom criticism meant instruction about values and the living of life. In our contemporary literature classrooms, such discussions come as something of a shock to those who expect only the dissection of a story's formal structure or its "symbolism," who have given up attempting to

understand students' lives, much less the effort it would take to influence those lives.

The feminist classroom that works on "images" becomes a place in which what is read helps students to examine systematically what they have experienced and what others have; a place in which what one has experienced becomes directly relevant to understanding and evaluating what one reads. One of the women in that class on Alice Walker said that the story had been a shattering one for her, since she, too, had gone searching her mother's house for objects with which to *decorate* hers, without any regard for her mother's life or feelings. The experience of such insights makes readers more, not less, demanding of literature. Such an approach to literature is novel only if one forgets about the traditional function of criticism—and of literature—to entertain and to instruct.

Studying the images of women in literature has at least two consequences: first, it raises teachers' and students' consciousness either as women themselves, or, if they are males, of women as human beings; second, and at least as important for those interested in the value of literature, the literary work assumes a new position as part of the patriarchal problem. Those who still prefer the idea of "pure" literature won't relish the value I am describing. I don't think literature is, was, or ever can be "pure," that is disengaged from its place in history. What is especially compelling about the study of "images" is that students are learning that literature assigned commonly in schools and colleges is part of an entire culture that has defined women as the second sex. Thus, literature is not more or less culpable than any other aspect of culture; at the same time, it is not to be ignored or despised as trivial.

Women Writers and the Literary Canon

It is hardly surprising that courses devoted to women writers followed soon after the establishment of courses on "images of women." It should be noted, at least parenthetically, that these have been more difficult to establish as "valid," since they constitute a break with the traditional (male) canon. They have also evoked a good deal of soul-searching (among feminists) and some hostile encounters (with antifeminists) about the act of "segregating" a group of writers on the basis of gender. Nevertheless, the value of feminists who continue to pursue such courses cannot be overestimated. For they, in concert with those pursuing "images," are providing the basis for revising the canon.

Before I get to the dimensions of the task before us, or even to a small assessment of the progress thus far, one general issue about the literary canon needs to be raised. The first issue—and the starting place for all the rest—is the passive acceptance of the canon, with and without the addition of Melville, Dickinson, and Donne during the twenties. I spent the year before this one on a fellowship, searching the catalogues of nineteenth century colleges and universities, looking for evidence that

during the first women's movement, there was some effort in departments of literature and history to offer courses in feminist polemical literature or in the sources and history of the women's movement. I found little but George Eliot, and people in English literature generally know how it was that *Silas Marner* got into the high school curriculum as a "modern" novel. I certainly never queried the curriculum, not while it was being taught to me, nor when I attempted to teach it to other students. Nor had I any sense of its sameness through the short near-century of its life. I remember feeling some sense of curiosity when I learned that Eliot had "discovered" Donne, and that, therefore, Donne was now required reading in seventeenth-century poetry courses; but I never bothered to ask how that had occurred, much less why.

Why is it, for example, that Rebecca Harding Davis' "Life in the Iron Mills," a story that Emerson in 1861 called a "work of genius"—and that *is*—never got into the canon? Or *The Awakening*, from the time of its publication in 1899 until 1964? Or, for that matter, black writers like Charles Chesnutt, W.E.B. DuBois, Zora Neale Hurston? Feminist criticism raises three sets of questions about this reality.

One: What has been left out of the canon? More than two years ago, Deborah Rosenfelt and I began work on a Goldentree bibliography of women writers in Britain and the U.S. from the renaissance to the present. Despite our "feminism" we were thoroughly unprepared—remember my initial "ignorance"—for the "hoards of female scribblers"—to use Hawthorne's term of opprobrium—we would find. And we can begin now to understand Hawthorne's competitive concern about the number of women writers, for there probably were more women than men writing and being published in the nineteenth-century United States. It was, after all, one of the few occupations open to women.

By the time we had begun this project, Goldentree had already published thirteen other literary bibliographies, containing some 977 male writers and 84 female writers, more than half of whom (43) came from two of the volumes, (*African American Writers* (22) by Darwin Turner and *Nineteenth-Century British Fiction* (21) by Ian Watt). Using bibliographies available in most research libraries, Ms. Rosenfelt and I found some 1000 women writers who merited inclusion. Since we were confined to one volume, and at first to 2000 entries, we were forced to choose no more than 150 of those writers. Even so, we accumulated some 10,000 entries for those women, perhaps eighty percent of which were primary sources, not secondary. And we had eliminated already such alleged ephemerata as children's books, juvenilia, single publications of poems or stories, journalism, and speeches. It is important to underscore that the sources of these thousand women writers were not the untapped manuscript collections just beginning to be catalogued, nor lost "gems" among popular fiction.

For each of the periods before the present, the lists of women writers are substantial, most of their work is out of print, little of it has been commented on critically,

and very little of it recently. A few examples: Elizabeth Stuart Phelps (1844-1911), who renamed herself after her literary mother, wrote some 57 novels, a couple of volumes of autobiography, and hundreds of shorter pieces. Only a section of the most famous of her novels, *The Story of Avis*, is available in an anthology that also includes a section of Mary Austin's *A Women of Genius*. Austin (1868-1934), a little more than a generation younger than Phelps, wrote 32 novels and more than 200 shorter fictions, as well as other books. Had I had *The Story of Avis* and *A Women of Genius* in hand at the time I asked about whether women should read fiction, I might have come to another conclusion. For *Avis* concerns itself with the attempt of a talented young woman to set aside her painting for marriage to a seminary teacher, and for the two babies that quickly follow that marriage. Unlike most nineteenth century novels that I had been brought up on, the pages recount not the courtship but the marriage itself, and the growing consciousness of Avis that she should not have abandoned her painting. Mary Austin's young woman also chooses marriage, expecting it to fulfill her needs, but leaves it for a career in the theatre—the novel was published in 1912 and its evocation of stifling small town life anticipates *Main Street* by eight years.

Apart from what has been left out of the canon—and I have not begun to touch on all the significant aspects of that question—the second question is in what ways do the works we are rediscovering force upon us a revised sense of literary value? And, as T.S. Eliot asked, how do these new discoveries alter our sense of works we knew? For example, if we place alongside of Henry James' *The Bostonians* Elizabeth Cady Stanton's *Eighty Years and More*, what happens to our perception of James' view of the nineteenth-century women's movement and our evaluation of that novel? It is not unlike placing side by side *The Blithedale Romance* and Fuller's *Woman in the Nineteenth Century*. Reading Stanton's life and Fuller's long essay brings into sharp relief the narrow understanding of feminism that, at the heart of each of Hawthorne's and James' books, end by corrupting their artistry. To write about people, a writer must know them well, in their political and social lives as well as in their personal relations. James and Hawthorne are ignorant or fearful of feminism, and their novels, therefore, become highbrow penny dreadfuls, the characterizations thin, the motivations obscure or absurd.

As I have already suggested, one significant effect of the addition of women writers to the canon has been a changed classroom. All through the sixties, at a women's college, I taught *Sons and Lovers* as the opening work in a freshman writing course, longing all the while for Miriam's side of the story, or some comparable piece of literature to set beside it. Of all the characters in the novel, my students could identify only with Miriam, but, they said, she was unsatisfactory as portrayed by Lawrence: why *was* she so sulky? *what* was that intensity about? what did she *really* want? why didn't she fight back? and most of all, what happens to her in the end,

when Paul Morel leaves her with his view that, for a woman, work is not enough?

Two years after I had left Goucher and had stopped teaching *Sons and Lovers*, I found Agnes Smedley's *Daughter of Earth*, thanks to Tillie Olsen, and The Feminist Press printed it—in 1973. Only once since then have I taught the two books together, but I recommend the experience. Smedley's novel was written in 1928, a little more than a decade after Lawrence's, and it is also autobiographical, about the early life of a working-class woman, whose father, partly Native American, was a coal miner in the southwest, and whose childhood was both as harsh and as occasionally beautiful as Lawrence's. Marie Rogers, like Paul Morel, wants to escape poverty, and like him, she has a mother who will help, a father who is a drunkard, a sister and two brothers. As in Lawrence's book, the key is education, the goal to become a writer, rather than a painter.

But the differences are as striking as the similarities, and of course, provide some of the excitement of study and discussion. In both novels, adolescent sexuality is important, and both young people are slow to develop, though Marie never loses the sense that, for women, sexuality is sinful. Paul survives two protracted love affairs that apparently enrich and enlighten him without touching his vital center. He is whole and free as he moves off at the end of the novel towards the bright humming city. Marie, too, survives two sexual relationships, but they cost her dear: the first includes two abortions and their accompanying physical danger and humiliation; the second, an attempt to combine marriage and political work, ends by denying her the possibility of both. At the novel's conclusion, she is destitute, without love or work. Indeed, writing the novel is her salvation: that is all we know from the book. From Smedley's life, we know that, unlike Lawrence, she did not then walk into a deep and satisfying relationship with a male Frieda. She—perhaps Miriam after all—spent her life working.

In the classroom, the novels are evenly matched—which is what makes criticism through discussion interesting. The stories are both compelling narratives, endlessly comparable with regard to characterization, style, imagery, as well as theme. There is even, in both, the contemporary Freudian mystique: Lawrence, influenced by Frieda; Smedley, in the analytic hands of one of Freud's own students in Germany, just before writing the novel. What is most fascinating, then, is that both male and female students find Paul Morel a “sniveling brat,” a weakling, placed beside Marie Rogers. They are struck by the differences between the responsibilities each has to assume even in similar class-bound societies. Marie, for example, whose mother's death occurs when

her brothers are too young to fend for themselves, has to decide whether to give her life to them or to herself. Out in the world of the factory, the young Paul is looked after by women who mother him as well as love him sexually, for him an enriching experience; out in the world—at a variety of jobs ranging from cigar-maker to travelling salesperson—the young Marie finds a couple of (unexpected) male “fathers,” but age is no deterrent for men who find young women engaging, and they prove ultimately dangerous for her.

I have not yet mentioned the single most compelling difference between the novels: the political perspective from which each is written. In some ways, Lawrence's can be viewed as a feminist work, at least in terms of his understanding of the limitations of his mother's life, and even, somewhat, of Miriam's and Clara's. But the novel's main attention goes to Paul Morel, his individual singularity, his future; and the experiences he undergoes with the three women are offered as preparations necessary for the life he is to lead as artist. The focus is on the working-class man who will, we know at the novel's end, leave that working-class life behind him, or who, at best, will be able to use it as subject for his fictional creations.

Smedley's novel is, even as the autobiographical narrative of an individual woman, something else throughout. She, too, is the supreme individualist, escaping from the grimy unfulfilled life of her mother. But at her core is a remarkable intensity about injustice, not only the injustice inflicted on her mother by her father, or on her, and not only the injustice inflicted on women. Fully one half of the novel is devoted to Marie Rogers' experience inside the political movement to liberate India. Marie's essential impulse, once free of acute poverty, is to put her life at the service of others who are enslaved. One of the novel's ironies hinges on the political rejection of Marie, not because she is American, but because she is female.

The third and last question about the canon leads directly into literary history. We know least about this question: what social, cultural, and political forces shaped the literary canon as it appears in traditional curricula and anthologies? Why, for example, do we require students to read Ben Franklin, and not Frederick Douglass or Elizabeth Cady Stanton, whose autobiographies were both in print by the time the American literary canon became established; and whose autobiographies are at least of equal merit and interest? Who makes such decisions? And on what bases? Is Franklin's merit the style he uses or the life he portrays? If the life, what are its major values? I've often been told that the major point is to demonstrate Franklin's industry. Well, no one is more industrious than Douglass, not only at the jobs he is required to do, but at learning to read, at a

time it was a dangerous ambition for a slave to hold. I know of no better book to offer to students who doubt the value of reading or learning in general. As for Elizabeth Cady, one would think that several women had to have been lodged in her one body—to account for the work she did in *Eighty Years and More*, in addition to bearing and rearing seven children. I don't want to belabor the value of Douglass' *Narrative* or Stanton's autobiography, but only to illustrate that the canon did not fall from the sky: rather, some people made decisions about books they would teach or foster; limited, sometimes racist and sexist decisions, rooted in cultural and social experience which we do not yet sufficiently grasp.

While no question about the canon is easy to answer at this point, some of the answers, it is clear, will be based on new forays into literary history. One of the most helpful studies in this regard is an essay by historian Carroll Smith-Rosenberg called "The Female World of Love and Ritual: Relations between Women in Nineteenth-Century America."⁴ Smith-Rosenberg traces the female friendships among "women and men in thirty-five families between the 1760's and the 1880's" representative of "a broad range of the American middle class, from hard-pressed pioneer families and orphaned girls to daughters of the intellectual and social elite." The range is geographically and religiously broad; the study is of "many thousands of letters written to women friends, kin, husbands, brothers, and children at every period of life from adolescence to old age" (p. 3). These letters are not what people in literature ordinarily regard as "literary," but rather they are documents for the historian. Smith-Rosenberg contends that they are especially valuable for the historian, since they are indeed "private," written only for the eyes of a particular correspondent. But her findings are of some consequence to the questions we have been asking, too.

Generously quoting from letters often painfully intimate, Smith-Rosenberg traces relationships between mothers and daughters, "the supportive love of sisters . . . the enthusiasms of adolescent girls . . . sensual avowals of love by mature women." "It was a world," she concludes, "in which men made but a shadowy appearance" (p. 27). She describes, in fact, a female sub-culture, in which female "supportive networks were institutionalized in social conventions or rituals which accompanied virtually every important event in a woman's life, from birth to death." She continues:

Such female relationships were frequently supported and paralleled by severe social restrictions on intimacy between young men and women. Within such a world of emotional richness and complexity devotion to and love of other women became a plausible and socially accepted form of human interaction. (p. 9)

If she is correct, and the evidence is persuasive, then we can begin to see the outlines of some of the work before us in reconstructing the literary history of women

writers and in understanding their omission from the canon. In the long run, seen from Smith-Rosenberg's view, the very idea of a canon of literature may emerge as one tactic, a kind of literary credentialing process, for limiting the potential strength of the female subculture. Similarly, it may become evident that the division between what is generally considered "art" and what is generally considered "handicraft" are themselves ideologies, serving key roles in the sexual politics of culture.

In a significant way, Ellen Moers has begun to reconstruct women's literary history, for example, by tracing for us the reading women writers did—mainly in the works of other women—and their own "networks": the extensive letter-writing across continents and oceans in the nineteenth century that substituted for the male literary world to which few of them had personal access.⁵ Several examples will have to suffice.

"The real hidden scandal of Emily Dickinson's life," Ellen Moers writes, "is not the romances upon which biographers try vainly to speculate, but her embarrassing ignorance of American literature"—by males, that is. Besides Emerson and a bit of Thoreau and Hawthorne, Dickinson "read and reread every Anglo-American woman writer of her time: Helen Hunt Jackson and Lydia Maria Child and Harriet Beecher Stowe and Lady Georgina Fullerton and Dina Maria Craik, and Elizabeth Stuart Phelps and Rebecca Harding Davis and Francesca Alexander and Mathilde Mackarness and everything that George Eliot and Mrs. Browning and all the Brontës wrote."

"Mrs. Hunt's poems," Dickinson wrote in an astonishing letter of 1871, "are stronger than any written by Women since Mrs. Browning, with the exception of Mrs. Lewes. . . ."

"Who but Emily Dickinson cared so much for rating women poets?" Ellen Moers comments rhetorically. *But in fact it is important to know that Dickinson's models were women writers*, and it should not surprise us, therefore, that a long-ignored verse narrative by Elizabeth Barrett Browning, *Aurora Leigh*, the *Sexual Politics* of its day, provided Dickinson with suggestions for at least seventy different poems. Similarly, Moers compares Jane Austen's life and reading with the circle that Wordsworth was part of, partly because of friendships formed at Cambridge, but also because he sought the company of literary men. "Jane Austen," Moers writes, "almost the exact age [as Wordsworth] and from a similar social milieu (has she been a man, she would probably have gone to university), stayed at home with her mother at Steventon, Bath, and Chawton" (p. 44). It is not that Austen had not read the "major [male] English writers": "But scholarship," Moers says, "has averted its refined and weary eyes from the female fiction that Austen's letters inform us was her daily sustenance in the years that she became one of the greatest writers in the language." And that list is an endless one: Sara Harriet Burney, Mrs. Jane West, Anna

Maria Porter, Mrs. Anne Grant, Elisabeth Hamilton, Laetitia Matilda Hawkins, Helen Maria Williams, and Mary Brunton, to name a few. It is obviously of some importance to feminist writers and critics to know that at least in the case of two distinguished women writers, art did not spring full-blown from their heads and hearts, nor did it depend solely upon male writers, but it grew both from their own experiences of life and from the tradition of other women before them. "In the case of most women writers," Moers concludes, "women's traditions have been fringe benefits superadded upon the literary associations of period, nation, and class that they shared with their male contemporaries" (p. 44-45).

Most tantalizing of all is the list of themes Moers provides for us in the one chapter she attempts as literary history, "as sample of the way such a history might read" (p. xiii). Women writers in their "epic age"—a period Moers designates as from *Jane Eyre* to Virginia Woolf—had one major characteristic: an involvement in social causes, including those of women like themselves, but also of the working classes, male and female, and of slaves. She finds close connections between feminism and radicalism and she finds a special sensitivity to the "theme of illiteracy," from which middle-class women themselves had only relatively escaped. She quotes George Eliot writing a letter to Harriet Beecher Stowe, "whom she honored as her predecessor in that great feminine enterprise of rousing the imagination 'to a vision of human claims' in races, sects, and classes different from the established norm" (p. 39).

Moers does not move on to make a connection between the absence of women from the literary canon and literary history—and the social causes they espoused. It is clearly too early to make such a claim, but it would not be a surprising connection. It would not be surprising if it were at least one of the missing threads to account for the loss not only from the literary canon but from general view of such works as *Life in the Iron Mills*, *The Awakening*, and *Daughter of Earth*. For after all, literary values, like other values, are institutionalized in social and political forms—magazines, departments, associations, anthologies, curricula, a canon—which provides

praise, money, legitimacy and power to those who control them. The powerless create their own forms—working people's reading circles, networks of correspondents—to assert their own values and definitions of what is important, beautiful, worthy of sustaining, and reproducing.

Further search will bring us many more Rebecca Harding Daveses, Agnes Smedleys, Kate Chopins, as well as Nella Larsens, and Edith Kelleys. Historical search will also bring more clearly into view the "institutions" by which women have sustained and transmitted their values and ideas and their means of survival. We have hardly begun a task of reconstruction that, I am certain, will also engage our daughters and sons, and theirs.

Should women read fiction? Yes, of course—and polemic, autobiography, poetry, letters, diaries, published and unpublished until we know the answers to all our questions and more besides.

¹ This essay was written in the Spring of 1976 as a lecture at the invitation of English departments and/or women's studies programs at the University of Cincinnati, Ohio State University, The University of Chicago, and Brandeis University.

² Those of you who study the program of the MLA Annual Meeting each year know that in 1975 there were more sessions than ever before devoted either openly to "feminist literary criticism" or to women writers. A single neglected Black woman writer, Zora Neale Hurston, had six papers devoted to her, at three different sessions. Despite the proliferation of sessions and the diminution of general attendance in San Francisco, these sessions on women writers were uniformly crowded, even when they conflicted with each other.

³ A glance at the program of the Third Berkshire Conference on Women's History illustrates my point quickly: at least one-sixth of the papers (25 of 157) depend (at least from their titles) on sources we might agree were "literature," and several (5) seem to be "literary" papers. Yet their subject and purpose in every case is the reconstruction of the lives of women in history.

⁴ *Signs: A Journal of Women in Culture and Society*, Vol. 1, No. 1.

⁵ *Literary Women*, Doubleday, 1976.

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